

THE MOTHER WHO REFUSED TO GIVE UP

TEXT: 2 Samuel 21:1-14 (NKJV) *“Now there was a famine in the days of David for three years, year after year; and David inquired of the Lord. And the Lord answered, “It is because of Saul and his bloodthirsty house, because he killed the Gibeonites.”² So the king called the Gibeonites and spoke to them. Now the Gibeonites were not of the children of Israel, but of the remnant of the Amorites; the children of Israel had sworn protection to them, but Saul had sought to kill them in his zeal for the children of Israel and Judah.³ Therefore David said to the Gibeonites, “What shall I do for you? And with what shall I make atonement, that you may bless the inheritance of the Lord?”⁴ And the Gibeonites said to him, “We will have no silver or gold from Saul or from his house, nor shall you kill any man in Israel for us.” So he said,*

“Whatever you say, I will do for you.” ⁵ Then they answered the king, “As for the man who consumed us and plotted against us, that we should be destroyed from remaining in any of the territories of Israel, ⁶ let seven men of his descendants be delivered to us, and we will hang them before the Lord in Gibeah of Saul, whom the Lord chose.” And the king said, “I will give them.” ⁷ But the king spared Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, the son of Saul, because of the Lord’s oath that was between them, between David and Jonathan the son of Saul. ⁸ So the king took Armoni and Mephibosheth, the two sons of Rizpah the daughter of Aiah, whom she bore to Saul, and the five sons of Michal the daughter of Saul, whom she brought up for Adriel the son of Barzillai the Meholahite; ⁹ and he delivered them into the hands of the Gibeonites, and they hanged them on the hill before the Lord. So they fell, all seven together, and were put to death in the days of harvest, in the first days, in the beginning of

barley harvest. ¹⁰ Now Rizpah the daughter of Aiah took sackcloth and spread it for herself on the rock, from the beginning of harvest until the late rains poured on them from heaven. And she did not allow the birds of the air to rest on them by day nor the beasts of the field by night. ¹¹ And David was told what Rizpah the daughter of Aiah, the concubine of Saul, had done. ¹² Then David went and took the bones of Saul, and the bones of Jonathan his son, from the men of Jabesh Gilead who had stolen them from the street of Beth Shan, where the Philistines had hung them up, after the Philistines had struck down Saul in Gilboa. ¹³ So he brought up the bones of Saul and the bones of Jonathan his son from there; and they gathered the bones of those who had been hanged. ¹⁴ They buried the bones of Saul and Jonathan his son in the country of Benjamin in Zelah, in the tomb of Kish his father. So they performed all that the king commanded. And after that God heeded the prayer for the land.”

INTRO: In today's Scripture reading, David is informed that the reason for the three-year-famine in the land, is due to King Saul having killed innocent people among the tribe of the Gibeonites. Israel had previously covenanted to protect the Gibeonites. Covenant relationships is a big deal to God and should be to us as well.

In his negotiations with the Gibeonites, King David agrees to allow seven of King Saul's sons to be surrendered to the Gibeonites. He did this despite knowing that the Gibeonites were going to take the lives of these men, to atone for the atrocities against them.

Two of these seven were sons of Rizpah and five were being raised by Michal, the daughter of Saul (Rizpah was Saul's Concubine).

RIZPAH COULDN'T PREVENT WHAT HAPPENED TO HER SONS

Rizpah watched in shocking disbelief as her sons were forced to pay for the sins of a leader who had been long dead.

She watched as the authorities showed up to take her sons into custody. I suspect that Rizpah did everything she could to convince the authorities not to take her sons. All to no avail.

How many parents in this room today have been confined to looking on in stunned disbelief as their children have been subjected to a disastrous turn of events. This happens through:

- Drugs...
 - Alcohol...
 - Lifestyles...
 - Relationships...
-

Many time's parents are confined to watching these things happen, seemingly in slow motion and there is not one thing they can do about it!

The Gibeonites hanged each of these men and left them hanging in plain sight for all to see.

These executions were not the fault of Rizpah or her sons. These executions were the result of a faulty decision of a King who had been long dead.

When we see our children drowning in craziness we must remember, it may not necessarily be our fault. If we raised them right, it is their decision to follow what has been inputted.

RIZPAH DECIDED TO DO WHAT SHE COULD

Once her sons were dead, Rizpah kept a vigil at Gibeah's hill where her son's corpses had been left to rot. She watched her two sons die in a gruesome manner, and now she suffered the humiliation of the shameful exposure of their bodies to the merciless elements.

Though she couldn't prevent their death, she refused to allow the birds and beasts to violate their corpses.

I want to prophecy to some moms in this building today, “*You may not have been able to prevent what has happened to your children, but you can pray!*”

Even though our kids may seem to be on a one-way trip to Stupidville, we still have the weapon of prayer. Those wayward children can outrun everything except our prayers.

RIZPAH WAS THE MOTHER WHO WOULDN'T GIVE UP

I am going to challenge every woman in this room today to become *The Mother Who wouldn't Give Up!*

There she was on her sackcloth rug - Her skin is brown and seared from the exceeding heat - Her hair matted by nights of wind and rain, yet, she

maintains her vigil! Her boys are dead but their bodies were being protected from the beasts and birds, by a ***Mother Who Wouldn't Give UP!***

All day and all night, for five solid months, Rizpah kept a vigil beating off the beasts and birds from her son's corpses.

The Bible says, from barley harvest – Which is about late April - To the early rains – Which is about October - She sat like a guard on watch, lest a claw or a paw be laid upon the faces of her sons.

Rizpah put her own life at risk to make sure her sons, who had been slain way too soon, received a proper burial. She no doubt had to run wolves, bears, lions and the such away from the site where her sons had died. She was the ***Mother Who Wouldn't Give Up!***

Rizpah is a story of determination that in my opinion, is un-matched in all of history!

She is one of the most persevering, persistent characters in the whole Bible. Can you imagine this?

- There was no place to grab a quick bite to eat...
- There was no place to take a shower...
- There was no refrigerator to keep food or drink...
- There was no friend to hold her hand or walk through this with her...
- There was no support group to sympathize with her...

Rizpah fought off the birds by day, and the beasts by night. She did this until she got the Kings attention, and the king gave her sons an honorable burial.

Ladies, if you are going to reach your children and loved ones, you must decide to be ***The Mother who Wouldn't Give Up!***

CONCLUSION:

If we display enough determination, we can get the Kings attention. If Rizpah could have that kind of determination for her dead sons, can we have that kind of determination for our living children?

We must be determined that our kids to know, they are loved unconditionally by us and by their Heavenly Father.

We must be determined that our kids know their purpose.

We must be determined that our kids know how to pray and declare God's Word.

Through determination, we can build godly homes, and pass down an inheritance that will last for eternity.

How can we do this?

- Pray for them every day!
 - Invite them to church!
-

- Talk to them about their eternity!
-